District Attorney Scaleria

"What do you mean that the feed went staticky just as bXJ0aW0 stands up?"

"I'm saying when the feed started to zoom in on the puking lady and Mr. Tim started standing up, something happened and the feed didn't really recover for a bit. By the time we got it back, we have footage of Mr. Tim walking back to his seat."

"And we have no other feeds on terminal 17?"

"No, sir."

"Do you know what could have caused the interference in the feed?"

"It would require me shipping out there and examining the camera in person to see what damage it had. And last I checked, there isn't a budget for me shipping out for UBI cases."

"What do you mean there isn't budget, we are literally flying out experts to testify in cases all around the galaxy to crack down on fraud in UBI."

"Unlike the fancy experts, I'm a feed technician and no one gives a shit what I think. They pay me to work the feeds and they ain't paying me OT just to ship out and look at a damned camera in a UBI case."

Anthony Scaleria, the district attorney for sector for quadrant 927 was pissed. What should have been a slam dunk case for the Commonwealth was being mired in crappy evidence and shitty witnesses. Thankfully, bXJ0aW0's case would be straightforward, he'd let the assistant DA handle the charging paperwork and witness list while he concentrated on Galgren. This would let him focus on the task at hand: how was he supposed to cut down on fraud in the UBI program if he was being forced to call in Dr. Stein as his "expert" witness. Unconsciously, his left tentacles all start rubbing his chin in turn while he works through this latest failure of evidence.

"Is it fair to say this establishes bXJ0aW0's position in the scene and gives us a timeframe that he was away from his seat which corresponds with the timeframe of the psychoergometer reading?"

"Yeah, that's accurate."

"Okay, this evidence isn't as useless as I thought. When I call you as a witness to testify in court, you have to call bXJ0aW0 by his name. You can't call him Mr. Tim, do you understand?"

"He's a 'droid', I ain't calling it by their little bits."

"Gary. I don't like to talk about politics at work. I am a lawyer trying to enforce the Commonwealth's laws. Right now I am asking you to not use racially charged language when you are on the witness stand. Do you understand?"

Gary, the feed technician, a goblinoid from K2-288Ba, draws up a big, fat loogie, spits it the direction of a feed that is showing bXJ0aW0, nods his head in understanding.

"Gary, if your prejudice leads you to lie under oath or falsify anything about that recording, I'll pursue whatever charges the evidence supports. Do we understand each other?"

"Thanks for coming by my office Anthony."

Willing to accept the disrespect given the context of the situation, Scaleria leaves the office of the feed technician. Realizing he has worked himself into a hunger, he leaves police headquarters and heads towards his cousin's sausage cart, Jmbob Jim's. The beautiful aroma of sizzling meats, synthetic herbs, and whatever nasty shit he was testing out on his favorite customers, Jmbob always brings Scaleria a huge smile. Just as he arrives at the cart, Jmbob rushes over and embraces him with all six of his tentacles.

"Cousin, you're so skinny. You never come around, not even to nonna's. What's a guy gotta do to spend time with his family nowadays?"

"Hey, hey. Jm I've been busy. I don't know if you listen to the feeds but I am leading in our local quadrants for UBI fraud crackdown. I am making a real difference."

"Yeah, there is a real difference in my income. You know like half or more of my customers are on UBI? You want to fix fraud in UBI? Maybe tell those politicians to make payments come on time. Maybe then I give a shit about fraud in happily paying customers."

"Shit cousin. They still got you by the balls on those payments?"

"Cousin, your goddamn friends wrote the fucking loopholes that bleed my ass dry every payroll."

"Hey I didn't know that. How much we talking?"

"Enough that the wife is pissed."

"Shiiiiiittttttt. How is she doing by the way? And the kids?"

"Family is good, cousin. They ask about you sometimes. You should come by for dinners."

"How does seven weekends from now look for you?"

"Cousin, I am held down by the old block and chain and the cement and the wall. Any weekend is a good weekend."

"Okay I will have my secretary block off time in my calendar and my driver will drop me off as you don't have parking nearby, right?"

"Cousin, you can't tease me like this. Did you buy another classic car?"

"Do you have parking nearby?"

"With your money? There is always parking nearby."

"Then I guess you'll have to wait for Sunday dinner to see what I bought."

"You sneaky sneak. Gotta get me riled up just at the start of a shift."

Scaleria gives Jmbob a formal bow and waits with his foremost tentacle out to receive the sausage roll that his cousin had been masterfully preparing during the conversation. Giving the roll a few extra moments to steam, Scaleria slowly unwraps the sausage, focusing on the pungent smell of the mustard as in interplays with the borderline legal grease Jmbob adds as part of his secret sauce. Taking large bites without room to truly savor, he devours it as if he is in an eating contest. Without skipping a beat, Jmbob hands him two more rolls and the process begins again. A few moments later, belly full of artificial flavors and proteins, Scaleria lets out a large belch.

"There isn't any way I can convince you to take over the cafe at the courthouse?"

"No way, cousin. Part of my secret sauce is the au jus of pollutants that add just the right amount of heavy metals and forever chemicals that I could never legally add to my rolls but without a doubt make them irresistible."

"Have you tested them for heavy metals?"

"Of course not cousin, if I did then there would be a record of it and no genius reveals their secrets. Especially when those secrets tow the line of legal."

"If I have run for higher office one day, you really will be the albatross around my neck, won't you?"

As if he received a huge compliment, Jmbob takes a sweeping bow.

"If you think my dealings are shady cousin, you really need to come to Sunday dinner more. Even nonna is working on schemes that make me look like a saint."

"I am going to walk away now and pretend I didn't hear that. See you soon cuz."

Pulling out his netpad, Scaleria initiates a call to Matilda, his newest clerk.

"Where are we at with other witnesses in the office that day? I need some good news."

"Well good news is we do have a witness that saw bXJ0aW0 approach Galgren."

"That's fan-fucking-tastic! Were they able to see bXJ0aW0 interact with the terminal?"

"No, their view was blocked. But there's bad news."

"Spit it out."

"The witness is a card carrying member of the OO. We're talking about a full blown biological eugenist of the Organic Order. A record full of hate crimes and even some dropped murder charges."

"So let me get this straight. We have psychoergometer readings that pretty much guarantee he was assisted by an android, but we have no footage confirming that, and our best witness to that point will immediately sway the jury away from our narrative. Am I missing something or is this really that shitty of a case."

"Well we do have the other witness, the one that got drunk with Galgren. She told us that Galgren told her that he froze up due to PTSD while working on the application."

"Yeah that helps, but it might as easily help the defense as well. Damn I wish the cameras could be installed on the terminals themselves, would really make these cases easier."

"I heard that some researcher is working on some new passive camera tech that doesn't interfere with psychoergometers."

"That's great and all and maybe when you're the DA you won't find yourself over a parallel in every case. But right now? Unless we find a critical piece of evidence or a new witness, we are relying on some pretty circumstantial evidence. Speaking of, I feel like I already know the answer but did we get the results back from the Inductively Coupled Plasma Mass Spectrometry?"

"We did. Unsurprisingly, we found too many trace metals so there isn't really any conclusion we can make. The tech was saying that sometimes a perp might have radioactive isotopes we can look for but in the case of the Turing61 they are built with bog-standard parts and bXJ0aW0 hasn't had any exposure to types of radiation we could detect."

"Nothing else came up in the background research right? Looking at other successful cases, there isn't a line of evidence we haven't pursued?"

"We still have the interns reviewing any case they can get their hands on but nothing yet."

Scaleria rubs his temples and uses the suction cups to gently massage the area he could feel a headache coming on. Without even thinking about it, his feet had taken him back to the courthouse. Like his dad had always observed, Scaleria has always been pulled to justice, in some cases quite literally. A flicker of doubt and a deep sense of shame washes over him.

"Hey Matilda, could you notify the health department to do a sweep of district 5?"

"Sure. Is this related to the case?"

"No. Just something that needs doing."

Needing something to distract himself, Scaleria runs up the stairs taking them three at a time and quickly finds his way into his office. Once inside, he grabs his favorite tumbler and gives himself a large pour of the top shelf whiskey he bought himself when he became DA. Allowing himself to fully focus on the burning sensation of the liquor as it made its way down the gullet, he didn't even notice the complex flavors he normally attended to. Right now he needed a buzz and he needed it now. A few minutes later and another glass poured, he finally felt like he could look at himself in the mirror.